

Dog Care Handbook for New Owners

Sample document written for RAG practice. General information only.

Daily exercise

Most adult dogs need at least one to two hours of activity every day, but the amount varies by breed, age and health. Working and herding breeds usually need more, while small companion breeds may be content with shorter walks. A mix of walking, sniffing time and play is better than one long, fast walk. Puppies should have short, frequent outings and avoid long runs while their joints are still developing.

Feeding

Feed a complete dog food suited to the dog's age and size, and measure portions rather than guessing. Most adult dogs do well on two meals a day. Fresh water must always be available. Some human foods are dangerous to dogs, including chocolate, grapes and raisins, onions, garlic and products containing xylitol. If a dog eats something toxic, contact a veterinarian immediately.

Veterinary care

Puppies need a series of vaccinations in their first months, followed by boosters as advised by a veterinarian. Regular check-ups, parasite prevention and dental care are part of routine care. Microchipping and registering the dog's details make it much easier to be reunited if the dog goes missing. Keep records of vaccinations, because kennels and travel often require proof.

Training and socialisation

The best time to socialise a puppy is in the first few months, by introducing it calmly to different people, surfaces, sounds and other dogs. Reward-based training, using treats, praise or play, builds trust and works better than punishment. Short sessions of five to ten minutes, repeated daily, are more effective than a long weekly class. Basic commands such as sit, stay, come and leave it improve safety.

Walking safely

Use a well-fitting harness or collar and a lead of a suitable length. In many places dogs must be kept on a lead in public areas at certain times of the year, so check local rules. In hot weather, walk early or late, avoid hot pavement, and carry water. Always pick up after your dog.